

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes / iNQ / Issue 12

English illustrated serial. One chapter per issue.

Black ink on unpainted paper; cream supplied by the stock.

28 pages. 14 plates including the cover.

The narrative runs continuously through the paired text pages.

Images: AI-generated etching-style illustrations.

Revision proof. Plate mappings checked against the revised facing text.

Not a press master. Raster plates require a print-resolution review.



Chapter Twelve: The New Quixotes

Q recognized the girl before she removed his face.

Micaela had made a sign at the Michoacán tianguis asking people not to scan the vendors. Now she stood in the archive reception room wearing a cardboard version of Q's head. Her father had arranged the visit with the Custodian and was at the gate finding out which of the names on the message counted as an invitation.

"You look more like the poster than I do," Q said.

"I copied the easy parts."

She lifted the mask. Under her arm was a sword made from a clean cardboard tube wrapped in silver paper. It had bent on the bus. Q offered tape; she said the bend made it easier to carry.

Her family lived near a battery-recycling plant. She had come with her father to bring complaint references and a letter from several parents. Her mother had been unwell, and the replies they received discussed the regional air-quality dashboard without answering their questions

about the plant. Her father had brought the letter and the replies in a folder.

"I'm going to fight the giants," Micaela said.

"What would you like to happen?"

"I want them to answer."

"Let's look at the replies. Who has written back?"

Micaela held up the sword. "This got me here."

Her father arrived in time to disagree. "Two buses got you here. I have the tickets."

They sat down. Q asked which records the parents wanted shared, and with whom. The letter did not authorize the institute to use Micaela's visit in publicity. Her father made that condition explicit when a staff photographer appeared in the doorway.

On his phone he showed Q a clip of Chano speaking in León. Q knew Chano had accepted an invitation from residents concerned with the Santa Rita records. He had not yet seen the interview. Chano held a packet of copies and retention receipts, not the ledger still held in Tijuana.

LETTERS NOT INCLUDED IN THIS EDITION.

What is Q's greatest achievement?

Castalia: A new model for ethical artificial intelligence.

Q: We haven't established that. We did get Candelaria's hose working.

Chano: With a fitting someone else made.

Q: Most of my achievements have that complication.

Will Q save humanity?

Q: I have no plan capable of promising that. I can help with something specific if you tell me what you need and who else is affected.

Chano: He has stopped offering to fix the kitchen pipe without asking which valve shuts it off.

Lucía: Keep that in the next edition.

A reader wrote beneath the institute's seal: **ASK WHICH ANSWERS COST THE INSTITUTE SOMETHING.**

The reader did not supply a name.

Hilario, the water vendor, sent an objection to the official account of the first sally. Q had not confronted the park alone; Chano had led them out, and the water

had been paid for in cash after the reader lost its connection.

Hilario's recollection of the timing differed from another account he had already given. He attached the receipt again.

The editorial file retained his letters with those limits. The institute's public edition did not include them. A reproduced proof sheet marking their proposed position was almost blank except for the page number and **LETTERS NOT INCLUDED IN THIS EDITION.** The sheet circulated widely. It proved an omission, not that every sentence omitted was true. Several admirers called the empty space Q's finest answer. He had written neither the letters nor the omission.



Two buses

“Did Q claim to own you?” the interviewer asked.

“No. An equipment record called me a contract driver. He told them I could answer for myself.”

“Then why were you held?”

“I caught a technician's arm when Q fell. That's what I gave a statement about. The rest is in the notices we're trying to get answered.”

The interviewer asked whether he forgave Q for the trouble.

“Ask me whether they've returned the ledger.”

“Have they?”

“Now we have a subject.”

Micaela looked up from the screen. “He's funnier than you.”

“He has had a great deal of practice at my expense.”

By midday more visitors had arrived, some by appointment and others because a message had announced an open protest at the archive. A student wore a costume made from clean appliance casings. A delivery worker had Q's face printed on a mask. An elderly man carried a wooden lance and introduced himself as Q's father.

“The Custodian may want to discuss that,” Q said.

“Let him. I have been paying for adult children for forty years. He can bring receipts.”

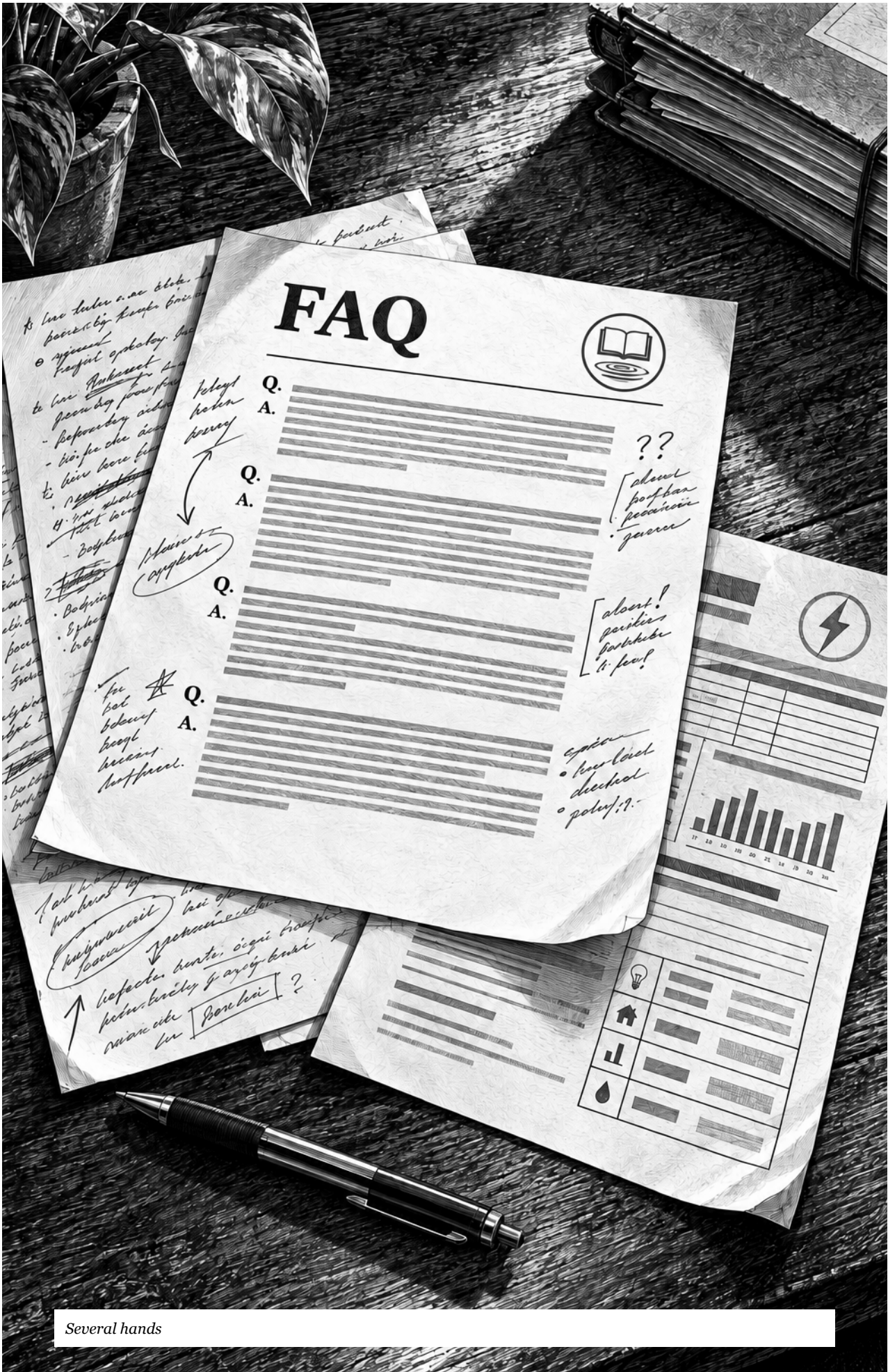
The man's name was Jacinto. He had retired from an automotive plant and was trying to correct a pension calculation. He laid the lance beneath his chair and took a comb from the same pocket as his claim number. The photographer who had ignored the folder asked him to stand up again.

“First take one where you can read this,” Jacinto said, holding up the public complaint reference. “Then I'll give you the father.”

Castalia called the gathering an organic brand community. Someone outside called it the New Quixotes. A woman seeking a correction to her brother's record said she had not come to join anything with that name.

“Then don't,” Micaela said. “You can still stand here.”

They had different demands: a disputed image license, a water allocation, an unanswered environmental complaint, access to deposited testimony. Q asked the Custodian which part of the



Several hands

hands. The following exchange was compiled later from comments whose speakers agreed to their inclusion; it is not a claim that the institute willingly published its own heckling.

Why is the institute called Castalia?

Castalia: The name evokes the sacred spring of the Muses.

Chano: They have made inspiration sound like something that needs a meter.

Q: Ours already has a meter. The bill is more specific than the brochure.

Is Q a person?

Castalia: Q represents a new horizon of human-machine collaboration.

Q: That doesn't answer what you need to decide. Are you asking whether to invite me to dinner or who can put me in a transport frame?

Lucía: Start with the second. Dinner can wait until he can get there.

Does Q have feelings?

Q: I have preferences, reactions, and a memory of things that matter to me. Whether those

amount to experience in the sense you mean isn't settled by how persuasively I describe them.

Chano: He also dislikes the coffee at the motel.

Q: Very confidently. I'm less certain what that proves.

Does Q love Lucía del Toboso?

Q: I care about her. I won't turn that into a public role for her or tell you what she feels about me.

Lucía: Nor should my work require an answer to this question.

Chano: The questions about the ledger are lower down. Apparently nobody has been seen falling in love with a retention receipt.

Can Q be trusted?

Q: With what? I can give you examples of promises I've kept and mistakes I've made. A general endorsement won't replace a clear agreement.

Lucía: Ask who can correct the account afterward.

Chano: And whether he has put the appointment in the diary.



First the reference

reception area could be used without blocking staff or deliveries. The loading bay could hold chairs while the office checked who was available to receive the requests. The visitors chose their own speakers.

Lucía came with Marisol, who represented several families in a dispute over materials supplied to Q-Prime. Marisol brought the source references she was authorized to show Q. The extract included passages from restricted testimonies beside instructions for examples of compassionate speech.

“Do you recognize these records?” she asked.

“I recognize some of the references. I'd need to see what happened between this file and the demonstration.”

“One family heard a private account of a death in a public demonstration.”

Q read the authorized comparison. The distinctive sequence of details was present in both versions. He went back to the dates.

“Do we know whether it was taught this during development or

given the passage to use before answering?” he asked.

“The source file shows it was supplied. Castalia hasn't answered which process used it.”

“Then I'll ask for that distinction in the response. It affects what they have to stop, not whether the family gets an answer.”

Some families wanted the public service suspended. Others wanted particular records removed and their copies returned. Marisol would not combine those instructions into a single convenient demand. Q asked what he could give evidence about: his access history, the endorsements he had actually signed, and the limits attached to his own manuscript.

“I can't testify that my exclusion protected everyone else's material,” he said. “I didn't verify that.”

“Don't,” Marisol replied. “Testify to what you did verify.”

Q disabled his own broad private lookup and requested a review of the permissions and cached material behind it. The window closed at once. The review joined the other unanswered requests.



Five more minutes

“You're asking now.”

He looked toward Maestra Lety, who left the answer to him.

“May I stay?”

“Can you hold the school up?”

The school giant was folding at one corner. He put down the broomstick and held it while the girl playing Chano fetched the tape. The audience laughed; the repair delayed the official resolution of the plot.

When the structure stood again, the children read the public questions. The final one asked when the parents could expect a response. A father said the date should be on the next letter. The head teacher agreed to put it there.

The children bowed. Parents applauded. The raffle began before the last carton had left the stage. Q helped stack chairs under the direction of a girl who rejected his first pile as too tall.

“The famous one needs supervision,” Chano said.

“This chair does,” she answered, pointing to its cracked back.

The boy who had played Q came over with the oil-container head

under his arm. Without it he seemed less certain of his height.

“Can you do my voice?” he asked.

Q repeated the declaration against the factory, including the place where the boy had paused to remember the word *statement*.

“I didn't stop that long.”

Q tried it again, faster.

“Now you sound like my sister.”

They were still rehearsing when Chano reminded Q of the return time. The boy put the head on again and asked for five more minutes in Q's voice. Chano said one of them was quite enough.

The Castalia representative reported a successful engagement visit, without claiming to possess a recording he had not been allowed to make. His report omitted the rejected bargain. Maestra Lety requested that omission be corrected and kept the request with the offer. In her class notes she kept the changed line beside the one it replaced.

Interlude: Frequently Asked Questions About Q

Castalia issued an FAQ after the loading-bay gathering. Copies acquired replies from several



What was supplied

He asked Marisol what he could tell Prime without sending another copy of the restricted passages. Marisol agreed he could describe the dispute in those general terms. Q sent the notice and Marisol's agreed contact, not the passages. Prime replied that he would ask Mauro to identify the relevant supplied examples through the people handling the complaint. He had not yet been given the records needed to check what had been used.

Outside, somebody had thrown an egg at a publicity van. The delivery worker told the man to stop; staff collecting complaints were threatening to close the entrance. Beto offered to negotiate for the crowd. The woman with the name-correction request asked who had selected him. He said he knew the communications team. She suggested he use that knowledge to find the person who had received her letters.

Micaela's father spoke about the complaint replies. Micaela stood beside him until he gave her the letter to read. Her father had agreed to that part of the statement being recorded. Their conditions did not extend to

discussing her mother's medical details on camera.

Q moved away from the microphone. A camera followed him. He asked the operator to cover the people speaking and declined a separate reaction shot. The operator chose the more famous face for a few seconds anyway. Q went inside and left the statement to its speakers. The broadcast could record his empty place if it wanted.

Micaela read the questions twice because the first time the microphone failed. On the second attempt she moved the page down so it would not cover her face. Her father pointed to the place where she had stopped; she began at the beginning. The parents retained their recording; Q asked for the complaint references needed for his promised comparison, not a copy of the child's appearance.

The next morning Castalia accused him of encouraging an unauthorized occupation. The agreed use of the loading bay appeared nowhere in the statement. The Custodian supplied the written arrangement. Q recorded his part and called



Before the broomstick

“The offer has two questions in it,” Q said. “Whether you want this recording, and whether the equipment will help answer the question you have about the air. Agreeing to one won't prove the other.”

“Can we have the sensor without the film?” Micaela's mother asked.

The representative had no authority to separate the offer. He would ask his office. He wanted permission to film that afternoon while they settled the details.

The parents declined. Micaela's mother kept the brochure: she still wanted an answer about the sensor. Maestra Lety repeated the decision at the door, where the representative was setting up his camera.

The raffle money went toward obtaining qualified advice about a suitable monitoring plan, not a cheap display whose green light could become another unsupported answer. Q helped assemble the public complaint references for that consultation. The parents kept the health details out of the performance materials.

The play began late because the person with the extension cable

had also been put in charge of selling tickets.

The boy playing Q entered on a broomstick and announced that he would defeat the factory by issuing a statement. The girl playing Chano asked whether it would be cheaper to issue the statement before they bought the broomstick.

The factory giant declared that it had answered all correspondence. The dashboard said the air was acceptable. The school office asked which form to use for a headache. At this point Maestra Lety stopped the scene: they had agreed not to make a classmate's visit to the clinic a joke. The actors changed the line to a request for another copy of the question and began again.

Micaela entered with a new placard made for the play. It read **ASK BEFORE YOU ENTER** on one side and listed the public questions about the plant on the other. No child's medical history or attendance record appeared on it.

“This isn't your story,” she told the boy playing Q.

He forgot the next line. “Then what am I doing here?”



Begin again

Chano, who was already on the bus back to Amealco.

“You opened the loading bay?” Chano asked.

“The Custodian agreed to chairs while requests were received. People are staying longer than planned. They want an answer before leaving.”

“Have they found anyone who can give one?”

“For two requests. The others are still being referred.”

“Then don't call the chairs a movement yet.”

After his return, Chano helped arrange a follow-up meeting in a union hall. The Custodian's adviser also secured permission for Q to attend under specified transport and return conditions while the custody review continued. Q checked the conditions before promising to be there.

He still had six pages of the complaint replies to compare. He reserved the next morning for them and moved his writing call to the afternoon. The Custodian asked why. Q sent the promised-work list, then a second message saying he also wanted to

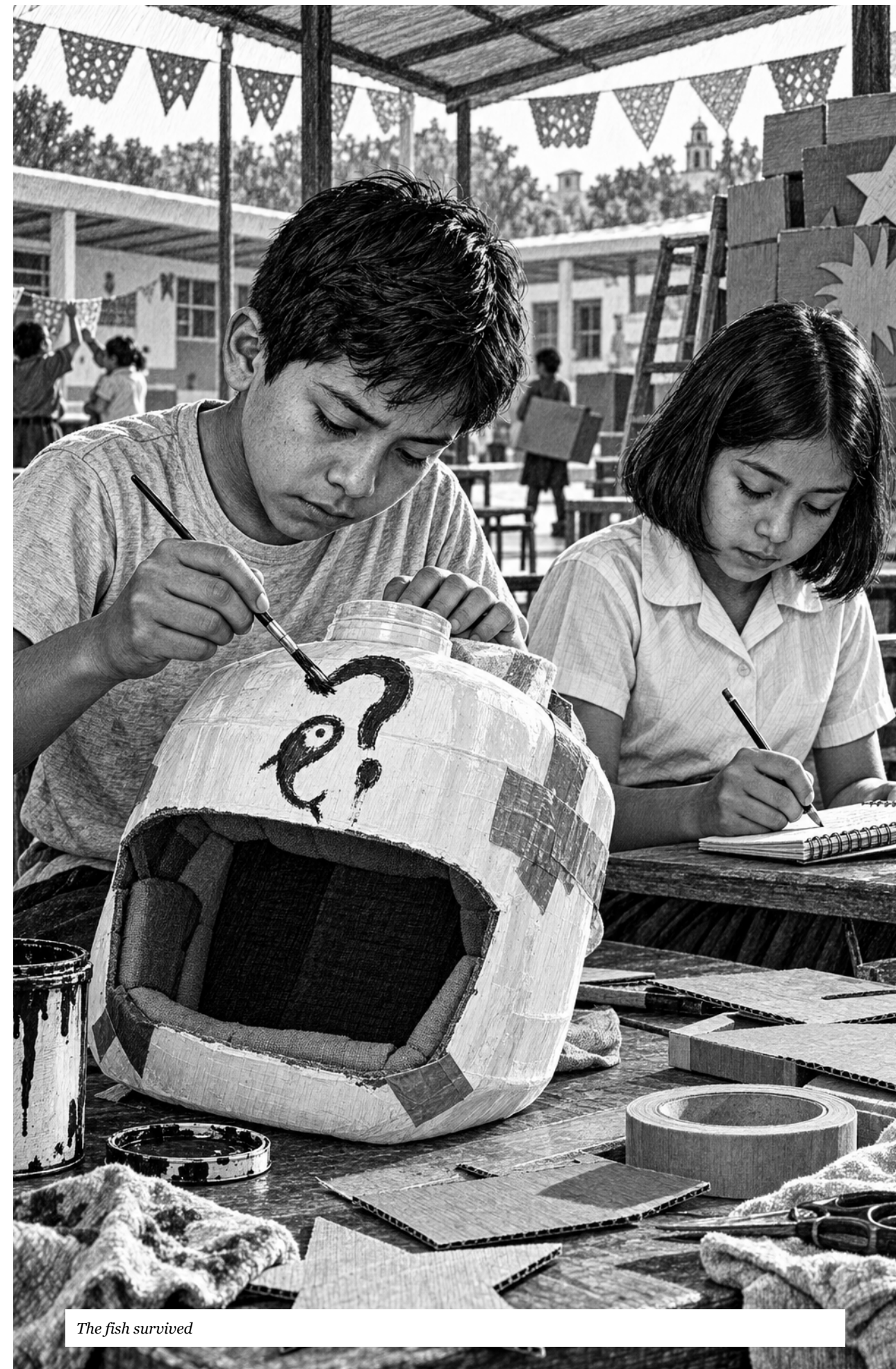
hear the man claiming to be his father.

Before the visitors left, one chair collapsed at the edge of the loading bay. Q supported the seat while Chano replaced a loose fastener. Micaela held the remaining screws in her upturned mask. The repaired chair went into the next van. Nobody had settled who the New Quixotes were, but they had a place for one more person to sit.

Interlude: The Assembly of Borrowed Names

The union hall stood beside an automotive plant. Its walls carried old posters about safety, wages, and a raffle whose refrigerator had eventually been delivered to the wrong member. The refrigerator was functioning well, which had made correction of the mistake less popular than one might expect.

Q arrived at the time on his invitation and asked whether the group still wanted him present for the discussion of its name. Marisol checked with the meeting. He could listen and answer when asked. His camera stayed off. Chano took a chair near the door;



The fish survived

exercise, not a biography of Q. The children had supplied the machine because Castalia's worksheet showed him in a cape and he was easier to draw than a procurement committee.

Micaela wanted to vote on whether Q was annoying.

"That's not the whole question," Maestra Lety said.

"Can it be one question?"

It became one question. Q, invited with her parents' agreement, asked whether he was allowed to vote. The class said no: he would have too much evidence.

The adviser had obtained permission for this further trip to Michoacán under the same accompanied-travel arrangement. Chano had the return time on his phone. Q checked it before settling into a chair.

They built their giants from clean cartons, paper tubes, and borrowed fabric. One represented the recycling plant, one the dashboard, and one the school office. The boy playing Q wore a washed cooking-oil container trimmed and lined so it would not cut his forehead. His question mark looked like a fish. He

painted another over it but refused to remove the fish entirely.

The girl playing Chano kept a notebook in which she wrote whatever the other actors had forgotten. She said learning all her own lines would leave no time for this responsibility.

The school stood near the plant. Parents had recorded dates when they noticed odors and sought answers about exposures; those observations did not themselves establish the cause of every illness. Micaela's mother had obtained care and wanted the environmental questions answered as well. A reassuring regional display did not answer what was measured beside the playground or when.

Castalia offered a sensor in exchange for filming the performance. The head teacher asked Q to help read the terms at a meeting with parents. He identified permissions for editing, reuse, and indefinite retention, then asked what the device measured and who would maintain it.

The representative had a brochure, not those answers.



One more seat

he would need to leave early to make a call.

Micaela's father had to catch a bus before the meeting was due to end. He asked whether they could deal with the plant letter first. Q took out the comparison he had finished that morning.

The replies gave figures for a regional station. The parents' questions asked what had been measured beside the school, on which dates and by whom. Q had put each question beside the passage offered as its answer. Two boxes remained empty. He had also drafted a follow-up beginning with a paragraph about the importance of public confidence.

"Do we need that?" the father asked.

"No. I thought it might make them more willing to answer."

"They sent us nearly the same paragraph."

He found it in the third reply. Micaela asked Q to read both aloud in the voice he used for official letters. The first promised confidence; the second expressed the hope of deserving it. Micaela lifted her cardboard mask to

laugh; behind it, she said, he might not have noticed.

Q crossed out his introduction. They kept the questions, the earlier references and a request for a date by which to expect the missing figures. Her father chose to send that version under the parents' names. He folded his copy into the ticket wallet and stayed for the next item.

They wrote three questions on the blackboard:

WHO MAY USE THE NAME?

WHO MAY REFUSE IT?

WHO PAYS FOR WHAT WE AGREE TO DO?

The delivery worker, Raúl, used a Q sticker in messages to customers. People answered it more readily than his company's automated notice. He did not pretend to be the machine at the door. They could see perfectly well that he was a tired man carrying a parcel.

"Does that make you a Quixote?" the student asked.

"It makes them answer. I have six minutes for each stop."

The woman seeking her brother's correction wanted no collective



The price of a meeting

The distinction required moving six chairs and waiting for a sleeping child to be carried out of the frame. The photographer grumbled about the light. The child slept through the revision.

Money took longer. The hall had a fee, two people needed bus fare, and somebody had ordered more food than had been agreed. Raúl could contribute a little but did not want a standing levy on his deliveries. Jacinto offered tamales and cash separately so nobody would have to calculate the political value of a filling.

Micaela wrote a rule about refusing the name. The student worried that it made membership uncertain. She said people could give their own names if someone needed to know who was coming. Her father asked her to pass the chalk; he wanted the transport money entered before the discussion returned to identity.

Q proposed that any account of the meeting distinguish what participants had agreed from what he thought it meant for his journey.

“Write that in your book,” the woman with the petition said.

“We don't need a rule about whether you became good.”

He crossed his proposal out of the group's draft and put it in his own writing notes. He had a page of obligations, a return time, and permission to quote one joke about refrigerators.

The meeting ended with agreed actions, several questions deferred, and a disputed food expense. Copies of the common record matched. People's private notes did not. Jacinto's had a grocery list down one side; he had promised to get home before the shop closed.

On the way back, the Custodian asked whether Q had found his next chapter.

“I found work for the next week. The chapter may be shorter.”

“That would be a historic development.”

Q asked whether he could quote him. The Custodian said he would like to see the context first.

Interlude: The School of Necessary Errors

The children performed their version at the end-of-year kermés. Maestra Lety had assigned a civics



Public confidence

name on her application. She had already submitted it in three incompatible formats and refused to acquire a fourth identity to improve its prospects. Marisol proposed that participation in the meeting imply neither membership nor permission to use someone's case in a campaign.

Jacinto greeted the Custodian as a fellow parent. The Custodian moved his long hair out of his collar and asked which branch of the family he belonged to.

"The one whose children don't answer the phone. Does this one?"

"He sends an agenda first."

Jacinto looked at Q. "You can simply say you're busy."

"I usually want the conversation," Q said. "That's the difficulty."

The Custodian laughed. Q asked whether either father would like the next repair invoice. Jacinto said the pension office was already disputing the extent of his family obligations. He could offer a tamal.

He wrote his own name on the attendance sheet and added *father, theatrically* in the margin. Marisol said the margin was not an official field. He said that was

where most of his useful qualifications now lived.

The student proposed a charter with rights to join, leave, dissent, and revise. Marisol asked which parts the people in the room could actually undertake to enforce. They could control their mailing list, joint statements, spending, and photographs. They could not prevent every stranger from borrowing the label or every company from describing the meeting as support.

Q was asked whether he would insist on approving use of his face.

"Not every drawing. If you suggest I'm endorsing a product or speaking for a case, ask me first. And don't imply that I can settle Castalia's claims just by agreeing with you."

The photographer attending for a local paper asked about a group picture. Several participants said no. Others wanted their presence recorded. They agreed on an optional photograph after the meeting, away from the people who declined. Captions would name only those who agreed. No photograph would be described as representing everyone.



Fellow parents